

The Honourable BANDIT

In true filmic fashion, this novel portrays the moral universe of a likeable outlaw



THE CONFESSION
OF SULTANA DAKU

by SUJIT SARAF

Viking

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| By Gillian Wright |

There is nothing to compare with an old-fashioned dacoit versus police adventure story. *The Confession of Sultana Daku* is just such a book. Taking inspiration from the footnotes of north Indian history, Sujit Saraf's novel bowls along, carrying you effortlessly with it.

His central character, Sultana Daku, tells his own story. In a time-tested, filmic fashion he sends a message to a Sahib who has helped hunt him down, to meet him on the night before his execution. The Sahib responds to this mysterious invitation and finds himself at the dead of night sitting on the other side of the bars of the cell of the dreaded dacoit, who squats before him. The Sahib, like many before and after him, is an amateur ornithologist and keeps a diary. He therefore has a pen and paper and obliges Sultana Daku by writing down the story of his life and promising to pass it on to his young son who lives with a group of reformed members of his father's criminal tribe. In this book, you have to suspend your disbelief. The Sahib writes in English, and the Daku will not know English, nor, more is likely, will his young son.

The other device that Saraf uses is the juxtaposition of Sultana Daku's own racy version of events recounted in his inimitable rustic style with the events as they are recorded in the sober words of the Sahib's diary. The two only roughly tally, leaving the reader to decide which is nearer the truth.

Sultana, who naturally dominates the book, comes across as thoroughly likeable. He avoids bloodshed where possible and is deeply attached to his horse, Chetak, and his dog, Rai Bahadur. He is a dacoit because he is following his dharma as a member of a criminal tribe. The British designated a number of communities as criminal and enacted legislation to keep tabs on them. Sleeman of Avadh wrote of these communities, "They extend their depredations into remote districts, and the booty they bring home with them they share liberally with the native police and landholders under whose protection they live." In Saraf's book, Sultana Daku does not share his loot with such local notables. His main allies, apart from his gang, are other criminal tribes, and the banias who are also his main victims. The banias in particular become major characters in Sultana's story.

The British made efforts to reform the criminal tribes by making them settle down as farmers. A contemporary source records of the Bawaria community, "The people settled regularly enough, and have reclaimed a considerable area of wasteland, but have not in the least degree reformed." Sultana Daku and his gang ultimately conform to this pattern. As a child, Sultana lived in Najibabad Fort under the supervision of The Salvation Army, known as the Mukti Fauj. The fort operates as a kind of open jail, and years of good behaviour lead to certification as a person of good character. Sultana could have been a "nekmash", as such people were known, but fate draws him into his ancestral profession.

There are some things that jar in the book—acorns in a terai forest, orioles screeching (they don't), and mangalsutras worn on the head rather than round the neck. And then there is an unfortunate Slumdog moment when the young Sultana jumps into George V's shit. But these don't detract from a really good and unusual read. ■

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